# Training Resources

The courses, books, tools and certifications I use to move into IT: help desk first, then Linux, networking, cloud and DevOps.

*Last updated October 2026. Every resource below is free unless it is a certification exam. Click any blue name to open it. Phases match my Learning Roadmap.*

## How I study

Weekday sessions are about one hour of videos or reading, with notes in my own words. Saturdays are hands-on labs where I type every command myself. Sundays are review: flashcards, quizzes and planning the next week. My notes are kept as text in this GitHub repository. I use Anki for spaced-repetition flashcards, and I save practice exams for the last two weeks of each certification, scheduling the real exam only after scoring 85% or higher several times in a row.

## Certifications

| Resource | What I use it for | Phase |
|---|---|---|
| CompTIA A+ (Core 1 and Core 2) | Hardware, operating systems, networking, security and troubleshooting. Two exams, both required. | Phase 2 |
| AWS Certified Cloud Practitioner | First cloud credential. Core AWS services, security, pricing and support. | Phase 3 |
| AWS Solutions Architect Associate | The cloud certification most job postings recognize. Designing secure, resilient, cost-optimized systems. | Phase 5 |
| HashiCorp Terraform Associate | Infrastructure as code: writing and managing cloud resources with Terraform. | Phase 5 |
| Network+ and Security+ (optional) | Networking depth and a possible security track. Taken only if an employer asks. | Optional |

## Phase 1: Command line, Linux and Git

| Resource | What I use it for | Phase |
|---|---|---|
| Linux Journey | Beginner-friendly Linux lessons from the command line up to permissions, processes and packages. | Phase 1 |
| OverTheWire: Bandit | A game that teaches Linux commands by solving real challenges in a terminal. | Phase 1 |
| The Linux Command Line (free book) | Reference and reading for the shell, pipes, redirection and scripting. | Phase 1 |
| Ubuntu command line tutorial | First steps in the Ubuntu terminal. | Phase 1 |
| Pro Git (free book) | How Git works and how to use it day to day. | Phase 1 |

| Resource | What I use it for | Phase |
|---|---|---|
| GitHub Skills | Hands-on courses for GitHub, starting with Introduction to GitHub. | Phase 1 |

## Phase 2: CompTIA A+, Python and networking basics

| Resource | What I use it for | Phase |
|---|---|---|
| Professor Messer: A+ Core 1 course | Free video course covering every Core 1 (220-1201) exam objective. | Phase 2 |
| Professor Messer: A+ Core 2 course | Free video course covering every Core 2 (220-1202) exam objective. | Phase 2 |
| A+ Core 1 pop quizzes | Daily quizzes for retention. | Phase 2 |
| A+ Core 2 pop quizzes | Daily quizzes for retention. | Phase 2 |
| CS50P (Harvard) | Free Python course with lectures and problem sets. My main Python course. | Phases 2 and 4 |
| Practical Networking | Clear explanations of subnetting, IP addressing and how networks work. | Phases 2 and 4 |

## Phase 3: AWS Cloud Practitioner

| Resource | What I use it for | Phase |
|---|---|---|
| AWS Skill Builder: exam prep plan | Official study plan, practice questions, pretest and practice exam for CLF-C02. | Phase 3 |
| Cloud Practitioner exam guide | The official list of what the exam covers. | Phase 3 |
| AWS Free Tier | Free-tier account for hands-on labs. I keep a budget alert on and shut down every lab afterward. | Phases 3 to 5 |
| AWS Certification account | Where exams are scheduled and certifications are tracked. | Phases 3 to 5 |

## Phase 4: Building the cloud toolkit

| Resource | What I use it for | Phase |
|---|---|---|
| boto3 quickstart | Automating AWS from Python scripts. | Phase 4 |
| Exercism: Python track | Daily Python practice with small exercises. | Phase 4 |
| Network+ N10-009 course | Free networking course for the deeper networking phase. | Phase 4 |
| Docker Get Started | Containers: building, running and shipping them. | Phase 4 |

| Resource | What I use it for | Phase |
|---|---|---|
| Cloud Resume Challenge | My portfolio project: a resume site on AWS with a Lambda visitor counter and automated deploys. | Phase 4 |
| GitHub Actions quickstart | Automating deployments from GitHub. | Phase 4 |

## Phase 5 and beyond: Solutions Architect, Terraform, Kubernetes

| Resource | What I use it for | Phase |
|---|---|---|
| Solutions Architect exam prep plan | Official Skill Builder study plan for SAA-C03. | Phase 5 |
| Solutions Architect exam guide | The official list of exam domains. | Phase 5 |
| Terraform AWS tutorials | Hands-on Terraform on AWS. I rebuild my resume project with it. | Phase 5 |
| Terraform Associate (004) prep | Official prep tutorials for the exam. | Phase 5 |
| Kubernetes tutorials | Official tutorials, planned for year 2. | Year 2 |
| Security+ SY0-701 course | Optional security track. | Year 2 |

## Tools and home lab

| Resource | What I use it for | Phase |
|---|---|---|
| Ubuntu | My daily learning OS (dual boot on my laptop). Ubuntu Server is for the home lab. | All phases |
| VirtualBox | Virtual machines on my laptop for labs. | Phases 2 and 3 |
| Visual Studio Code | Code and notes editor. | All phases |
| Anki | Spaced-repetition flashcards for commands, ports and AWS services. | All phases |
| Proxmox VE | Free virtualization platform for the always-on home lab machine. | Phase 4 |
| Used mini PC guide | Choosing an inexpensive used mini PC for the lab. | Phase 4 |
| Managed switch guide | Choosing a budget managed switch to practice VLANs. | Phase 4 |